

Ports of Plague

5-Minute Presentation Outline

Talking points for presenting the game to the class. Times are a guide; aim for about 5 minutes total, then take questions.

1. HOOK (0:00–0:30)

- "In October 1347, twelve Genoese galleys sailed into the harbor of Messina in Sicily, carrying a disease that would kill somewhere between a third and 60 percent of Europe." [TR-06, DB-01]
- "Our game asks: if you were a merchant then, would you keep trading?"

2. WHAT THE GAME IS (0:30–1:15)

- *Ports of Plague* is a board game played on one computer by 2–6 players, taking turns (hot seat). It has a painted map board, ships and carts sailing the trade routes, dice, cards and house banners, all animated.
- Each player is a merchant family based in a real trading city (Marseille, Genoa, Venice, Florence, Barcelona, London, Bruges, Lübeck). A dice roll at the start sets the turn order for the whole game.
- 12 rounds of half a year each (Late 1347 to Early 1353), or 6 rounds of a whole year in **Quick Play**. Three difficulties, from Apprentice to Great Mortality. About 27–60 minutes.
- **Goal:** the highest *Legacy* in 1353 = Wealth + Family + Reputation, plus your weakest category again. **Balance beats greed.**

3. HOW IT PLAYS: STRATEGY AND CHANCE (1:15–2:15)

- On your turn you spend 2 action points (3 in Quick Play): ship goods, open trading posts, move or protect your family, consult a physician, or give to charity.
- **Merchant's Ledger:** once the plague has passed a city, you can arrange a marriage or buy abandoned land there. You can also take a loan, propose a partnership to another house, or close your city's gates to rivals. [SO-12, EC-02, EC-01, TR-04, SO-11]
- **Fortune cards:** roll a 6 on the profit die or open a trading post and you draw a personal card (spice cargoes, extra actions, warnings of where the plague goes next, but also illness and nervous creditors), so no two players' games are the same.
- **Chance:** a profit die, a contagion die (infected cargo), a severity die for each stricken city, and survival dice for family members.
- **Strategy:** sea routes pay more, but cargo from a stricken city can carry the plague, even bringing it to the next city one round early. Fleeing keeps your family safe but costs reputation. Paying to hold a ship offshore, as Venice made ships wait in 1348, stops infected cargo from spreading. [ME-12]
- Comeback rules: inheritance, weddings, loans, cheaper charity, and Guild's Favor (an extra action for a house far behind). No one is ever eliminated.

4. THE HISTORY INSIDE THE GAME (2:15–3:45)

- **Real timeline and trade routes:** the plague reaches each of the 25 cities in the half-year it really did (Messina Oct 1347, Florence 1348, London Aug 1348, Bergen July 1349, Moscow 1353). [TR-06, TL-08, TR-09, TR-10]
- **Social responses:** flight to the countryside (Boccaccio), the flagellants, and Pope Clement VI banning them in 1349. [SO-04, SO-02, SO-03]
- **Persecution, handled seriously:** the Strasbourg massacre of February 1349 happened before the plague even arrived. The game states that the accusations were false, and players can only lose money by trying to protect the community, never gain. [SO-09, SO-07, SO-08]
- **Economy:** labor shortages raised wages and prices; England's Ordinance (1349) and Statute of Labourers (1351) tried to freeze wages and failed. [EC-03, EC-05, EC-06, EC-07]
- **Medicine:** the Paris Medical Faculty blamed the planets and "corrupt air"; physicians admitted they were helpless. The physician action shows real remedies such as bloodletting and figs and onions, and admits they did nothing. [ME-04, ME-06, ME-08]

- **The Church:** a quarter of the pope's court died; so many priests died that a bishop let the dying confess to laypeople, "even to a woman". [CH-02, CH-05]

5. ACCURACY AND RESEARCH (3:45–4:30)

- 85 facts from 37 sources (Britannica, peer-reviewed journals such as *Nature* and *PNAS*, university sites, and primary sources like Boccaccio and Guy de Chauliac). Every fact in the game is tied to a source.
- We show where historians disagree: the death toll, rats versus human fleas, and conflicting dates. [DB-01, ME-10, TL-04]
- We avoided anachronisms: no beaked plague-doctor masks (invented 1619), and quarantine appears only as "what came next" (Ragusa, 1377). [ME-11, ME-14]

6. BALANCE AND TESTING (4:30–4:50)

- We tested the rules with thousands of computer-played games. Every home city wins about its fair share, and a balanced strategy beats pure greed. Full results are in `docs/simulation-report.md`.

7. CLOSE (4:50–5:00)

- "In *Ports of Plague* you can't stop the Black Death. You can only decide what kind of family you'll be when it comes. That was true in 1348, too."
- Invite classmates to play; the Rule Book and Research Sheet are printed and available.

Fact codes in brackets refer to the Historical Research Sheet.